

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1137

By Keisling

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Geneva Bartlett of Celina.

WHEREAS, it was with great sadness that the members of this General Assembly learned of the passing of Geneva Bartlett, who will be fondly remembered as a beloved wife, mother, grandmother, influencer, teacher of generations, and friend; and

WHEREAS, a child of the Great Depression, Geneva Andrews was born in the Free Hills community of Celina in Clay County, which was established in 1816 as one of the first African-American communities of Freedmen in the South; and

WHEREAS, Geneva Andrews Bartlett was heavily influenced by her lineage as a descendant of the first settlers of the aptly named Free Hills, and her proud heritage inspired her to live in the form and function of communal responsibility; and

WHEREAS, as a child, Mrs. Bartlett attended the segregated Free Hills School in her community; at this small, two-room schoolhouse, she prepared herself for an expansive world of education, pride, and activism that would quietly intersect with legends both at home and abroad; and

WHEREAS, after graduating from Darwin High School, Mrs. Bartlett enrolled at Tennessee A&I State University (now Tennessee State University), where she pursued a bachelor's degree in business education and sang in the choir; she made money to support her education by babysitting for the children of Nashville's West political family, including future Nashville Mayor Ben West; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Bartlett graduated from Tennessee A&I in 1961, and armed with her degree and the spirit of a teacher, she returned to Free Hills School to begin her teaching

career, serving as the only teacher of grades one through eight at her alma mater until the integration of schools in Clay County in 1963; and

WHEREAS, having eagerly awaited the promise of equality via integration, Mrs. Bartlett was greatly disappointed to discover that she had been assigned the role of secretary in the newly integrated school system; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Bartlett possessed the fiery spirit for which her family was renowned and refused to accept this slight; instead, she successfully sought intervention that assured she would continue her career in a classroom setting; and

WHEREAS, teaching in Clay County schools for forty-one total years, with thirty-nine of those years being in an integrated setting, Mrs. Bartlett molded thousands of minds as a business education teacher, treasured librarian, and eventually, a Title I teacher at Celina K-8; and

WHEREAS, on Christmas Day 1962, Geneva Andrews wed her childhood sweetheart and the love of her life, Bobby Bartlett, in the church of their membership since birth, Free Hills Church of Christ; the couple was blessed with two daughters, Angela and Anita, who took after their mother as dedicated students and their father as student athletes; and

WHEREAS, she joined Sigma Gamma Rho Sorority, Incorporated, in 1960, and her daughters later followed in her footsteps as members of the sorority; Mrs. Bartlett was a member of the Kappa Tau Sigma Alumni Chapter of Sigma Gamma Rho at the time of her passing; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Bartlett also held memberships in the Home Demonstration Club, the Tennessee Education Association, and the National Education Association; and

WHEREAS, later in life, Geneva Bartlett continued to excel as a mother, "Nana," friend, aunt, cousin, and church member, singing enthusiastically at worship services; and

WHEREAS, Geneva Andrews Bartlett is survived by her loving husband of sixty-four years, Bobby Bartlett; daughters, Angela Bartlett and Anita (Darnell) Spann; grandchildren, Maidra Treece, Hillery Treece, Jameson Spann, and Jordan Spann; and siblings, Ann Hill Jackson, John "Sonny" Graves, Robert "Junebugg" Garrett, Jr., Connie Garrett, and Denise Andrews; and

WHEREAS, she was preceded in death by her parents, Ollie Mai Andrews Wilson Hamilton and Robert "Bud" Garrett, Sr., and siblings, Bea Audrey Isabel, Jack Andrews, and Austin Bailey; and

WHEREAS, Geneva Bartlett is deeply mourned by her loving family and her friends and neighbors in Celina, and we wish to pay our respects to a gracious lady who lived the examined life of the mind and soul while serving others with her big heart; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we celebrate the life of Geneva Bartlett, even as we honor her memory and mourn her passing, remembering her life of purpose and commitment to education and mentorship.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.